

Alternative Proposals for Anderson Road and Cesar Chavez Elementary School Improvements

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1 Introduction

The plans for Anderson Road and Cesar Chavez Elementary School (CCE) improvement as presented to the community on Sept 11, 2025, are deeply and fundamentally flawed. The design does not align with the priorities of the community. As will be explained below, no single segment of the community will be left unscathed by this design. Going forward, the author insists on more community involvement throughout the process, particularly to develop design principles and priorities, and explore top-level strategies. Before any major infrastructure changes are made, we need quantitative estimates followed by pilot studies to validate those estimates and obtain community feedback. This proposal will explain the flaws in the current design, suggest design priorities and constraints, and suggests top-level strategies. The proposal also presents some example design concepts which demonstrate that the design priorities can be achieved within the proposed design constraints.

2 Flaws in the Presented Design

No throughput calculations were presented at the meeting. Without employing valet's, the typical throughput of a single-lane curbside passenger loading zone is 150-240 cars per hour. In the twenty minute peak drop-off period, that amounts to 30-80 cars. That number might seem unbelievably low upon first hearing it, and so it deserves some explanation. The best practice is to have a curbside passenger loading zone with a limited number of places and a longer single direction queue to enter the loading zone. Suppose there are four parking spaces in the loading zone, in perfect continuous operation, with 30 seconds to park, and 30 seconds for the students to exit their vehicle. That would accommodate 240 cars per hour. You might try to have space for more than four vehicles in the loading zone, but extra space at the front is not accessible to cars in the queue while cars unload in the spots further back. If you have ever sat in the back of a large plane, you are familiar with this effect. With professional traffic management personnel, one can do somewhat better than these estimates, but why would we build out infrastructure that requires increased personnel cost in perpetuity, unless we had no other choice?

By now it should be clear that during morning drop-off, the on-site queue will fill immediately, and spill out into the surrounding area. The proposed design dramatically exacerbates the problem by having three competing entry paths into the queue: northbound on Anderson, southbound on Anderson, and westbound on Rutgers. These drivers are going to be competing to maintain their place in the queue. This will inevitably lead to counter-productive driver behavior, such as blocking

the intersection to hold one's place. Here again, highly active management (e.g. a police presence) can improve things, but why would we implement a traffic design that creates these problems in the first place?

So far, we have only considered community members who are dropping-off students by motor vehicle, but the deep flaws in this design ripple outward even further, negatively impacting everyone in the community. An important consideration are the many UC Davis students that bike past CCE on Anderson heading south. In the current system, during drop-off, southbound bike traffic follows a bike lane that is being crossed by cars entering and exiting the loading zone. No doubt this was a driving consideration for this design, but it fails to improve matters, due to the new four way intersection at Anderson and Rutgers. To a bike driving along the upper edge of the "T", a three-way intersection (the current configuration) is significantly safer than a four-way intersection. The proposed four-way intersection will be occupied by frustrated drivers fighting for limited spots in a queue. Drivers will push the limits of metering and traffic rules in order to claim their spot in line, and bikers will be at grave risk. What about other bikers and walkers? Driver frustration is going to inevitably lead some drivers to claim any available bike path as an ad-hoc drop-off zone. This will push bikes into traffic or onto sidewalks, also negatively impacting walkers.

Implementing the presented design would negatively impact all of the community members, and come at a high cost to other site amenities. Traffic is brought directly alongside the kindergarten area, leaving parents nowhere to wait with their children. One of the few areas on site with natural shade, a seating area where we hold ice cream socials and outdoor performances, would be converted into a parking lot. The CCE facade, currently presenting a modest, calm, and symmetric parking lot, would be replaced by a sprawling and irregularly shaped parking lot providing no effective buffer between the drop-off chaos and school buildings. **This plan presented to the community on September 11, 2025 needs to be scrapped and reconsidered starting from a careful consideration of the community's priorities.**

3 Proposed Design Priorities and Constraints

The author proposes the following priorities all aimed at improving safety for the community:

- The current system puts cyclist traveling southbound past CCE at risk, because cars must cross and recross the bike lane in order to pull into and out of the curbside loading zone. The author considers improving this situation as the highest priority. See Fig. 1.
- There are conflict points between walkers and cyclists, most notably in the vicinity of the intersection of Anderson and Rutgers. (See Fig. 3 below.) The existing signaling and traffic guard do an excellent job of mitigating conflict between motor vehicles with pedestrians and cyclists, and we should not do anything to degrade that.
- The current curbside passenger loading zone southbound on Anderson is chaotic. If this chaos can be effectively reduced, we should do so, but only if it is not at grave cost to other more vulnerable members of the community. We should also be realistic about how much the chaos can be reduced: drivers that choose to drive during peak times will inevitably encounter (and contribute to) traffic, and some inevitable chaos will ensue.

It is helpful to impose constraints on a design that support community priorities and prevent inadvertent regressions while pursuing the project priorities. The author proposes the following constraints:



Figure 1: The existing curbside drop-off is quite chaotic, as shown in this photo presented in during the community workshop in 2020, but which could have been taken yesterday.

- **No single tree will be cut down.** Natural shade is a highly limited resource on the site, and there are plenty of alternatives to mitigate existing problems that do not require destroying any trees.
- **No additional on-site surfaces will be converted to motor-vehicle use.** This principle avoids the classic design anti-pattern of over-accommodating motor vehicle drivers at the expense of other community members.
- **Do not accommodate on-site drop-off for northbound motor vehicles on Anderson.** The site cannot accommodate these drivers at a reasonable cost to the rest of the community. These drivers will need to plan their route to approach from the north or use off-site drop off.
- **Do not create any new four-way intersections.** Pedestrian scramble can be an effective way to improve upon an existing four-way intersection, but it only mitigates problems. It is a much better approach to simply avoid having a four-way intersection in the first place.
- **Be quantitative.** Estimate the throughput of various modes of traffic and compare it to the measured throughput of the existing system (the author has already begun collecting such data independently). Conduct pilot studies to validate the quantitative estimates before investing in any significant infrastructure investments.

4 Proposed Top-Level Strategies

The author proposes a few different top-level strategies for consideration:

- **Minimalist Approach:** The existing system has some flaws, most noticeable as the chaos during morning drop-off that most negatively impacts southbound cyclists on Anderson. This approaches would attempt to mitigate these problems using only small incremental changes.

- **Realistic On-Site Drop-off Approach:** A carefully designed on-site drop-off could reduce chaos, but it must be realistic about throughput, and plan to accommodate the queue that will inevitably spill off site. It should follow best practices for curbside passenger loading zones, most importantly, having one single access route (e.g. southbound on Anderson) to avoid conflicts.
- **Widen the Project Scope:** This approach would be more ambitious and consider Anderson, Oak, and Sycamore as part of an integrated traffic system that supports three schools sites and the surrounding communities in a coherent way. This could include making roads one way, either during peak times or permanently, and other dynamic and transformative measures. While the author encourages such big thinking for our city, it is beyond the scope of this proposal to flesh this out any further.

5 Minimalist Design Concept

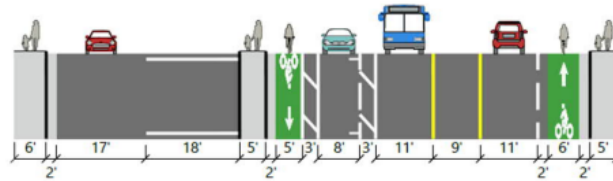


Figure 2: In the Concept 1 presented to the community back in 2020, the bike lane is relocated to the right-hand side of the curbside drop-off vehicles.

The existing infrastructure has flaws but is serviceable, and we should seriously consider a minimalist approach that makes only slight changes necessary to achieve the priorities from Section 3. This approach would keep the existing off-site curbside passenger loading zone unchanged, and would not modify school property to accommodate on-site drop-off. Central to this approach is avoiding making any other upgrades to the site that would trigger new requirements for major changes such as on-site passenger loading zones.

The biggest problem in the present configuration is the crossing of the bike lane with the curbside drop-off southbound on Anderson, as illustrated in Fig. 1. The minimalist approach would be to improve matters, particularly for cyclists, but leave the loading zone in or near its present location. The bike lane clearly needs to be relocated. In the Concept 1 presented to the community in 2020, the bike lane was simply relocated to the right-hand side of the passenger loading zone, as shown in Fig. 2. The concept includes a three-foot buffer to mitigate conflict between passengers being dropped off and the bikes. Other relocations are possible. Using a pedestrian scramble type signal, the southbound bike lane could be moved across the street, alongside the northbound bike lane, protected from on-coming traffic by parked cars or physical barriers. Another option is to redirect the bike lane into or around the CCE parking lot.

The second biggest safety issue arises from conflicts between cyclists and pedestrians at the intersection of Rutgers and Anderson. As shown in Fig. 3, cyclists arriving at CCE are generally trying to reach the access road that leads to the bike lock station. Generally, cyclists take two approaches, using the curb cuts to either the left or right of the red curb shown in the picture. If they go to the left, they conflict with pedestrians crossing Anderson or arriving on campus from the



Figure 3: The westside landing at the intersection of Anderson and Rutgers. Cyclist arriving at CCE are generally attempting to reach the black access road to the right of CCE, in order to reach the bike lock station, but they have no designated path.

north. If they go to the right, they conflict with pedestrians entering from the north at a particularly narrow and awkward section of curbing. Simple measures like widening the curb cut and designating a bike lane, including a connection to the access road alongside CCE, would dramatically improve the situation. A little paint goes a long way in this context. Presumably, this is also an emergency access corridor, but one can still imagine making this space more aesthetically appealing by adding vegetation and shade features, without disturbing any of the critical infrastructure or access.

The minimalist approach would leave the chaotic passenger loading zone in its present off-site location. But with the bike lane relocated and children exiting from curbside, the safety risk resulting from this chaos is minimal. The primary risk is low-speed collisions of motor vehicles. There are policy changes that CCE could make in order to reduce peak demand and thus reduce the chaos. Staggering student arrival times by grade and having longer arrival time windows could spread out the drop-off frenzy, calming some of the chaos. Adding additional off-site curbside passenger loading zones further away, but still in easy walking distance for older CCE students, would also reduce congestion at the existing loading zone.

It should be understood that however chaotic the current loading zone appears, it has higher throughput than all but the best managed on-site single-lane passenger loading zones. The chaos is from cars leaving and exiting at multiple locations simultaneously, allowing throughput at a scale that an on-site drop-off at this site will never be able to accommodate. The chaos also encourages drivers to consider other forms of transportation.

6 Realistic On-Site Drop-off Design Concept

A design concept that implements an on-site passenger loading zone is presented in Fig. 4. Anderson road at CCE currently has three traffic lanes (including an under-utilized shared middle lane) plus bike lanes, parking, and a curbside passenger loading zone. This concept repurposes the shared middle lane as a dedicated through lane for southbound traffic on Anderson. This accommodates through-lanes for both northbound and southbound traffic on Anderson plus a dedicated lane for

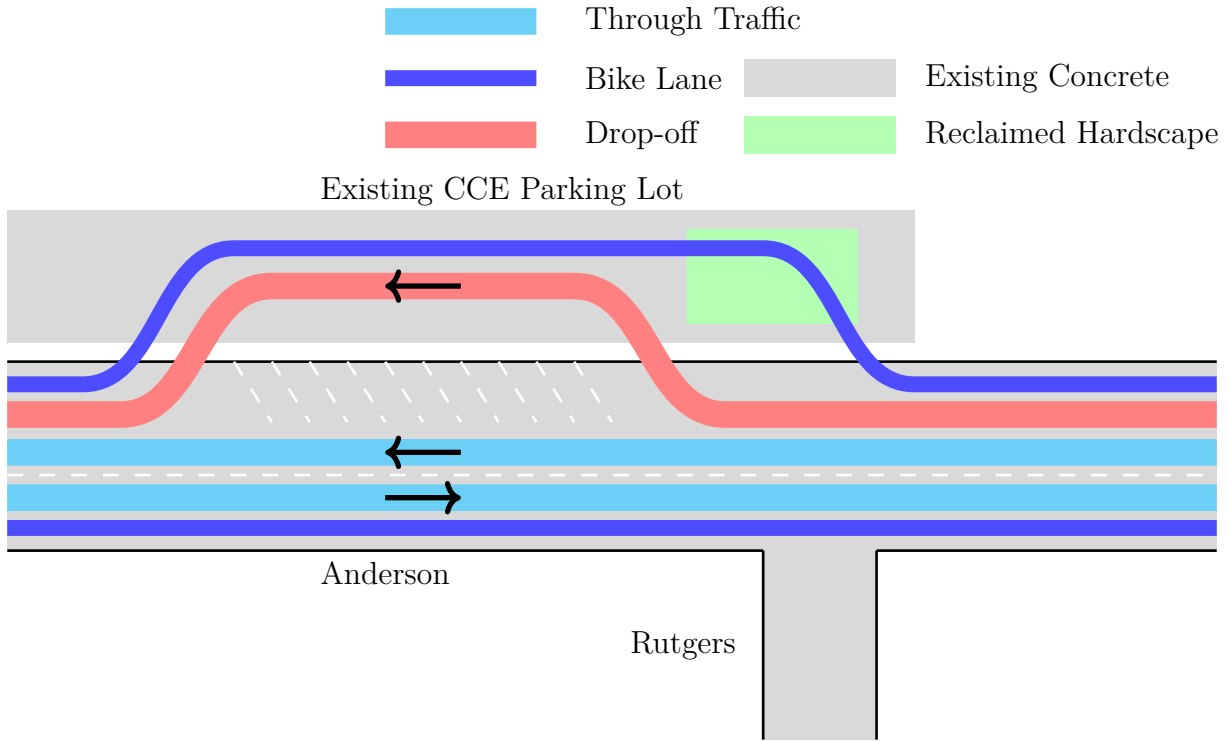


Figure 4: A proposal that accommodates an on-site drop-off. The essential feature is that entrance to the loading zone is limited to southbound traffic on Anderson, as the best way to accommodate the inevitable queue.

access to the CCE on-site drop-off. The entrance to the on-site drop-off is intentionally offset from the intersection of Anderson and Rutgers in order to avoid creating a new four-way intersection. Access to the drop-off is also limited to southbound vehicles on Anderson, in order to accommodate the inevitable queue that will develop. Physical barriers could be used to prevent drivers from Rutgers or northbound drivers on Anderson from attempting to enter. To reduce demand on the on-site loading zone, off-site passenger loading zones within easy walking distance for older CCE students should be included in the design.

The bike lane is diverted in order to avoid crossing the path of the drop-off traffic. The space on Anderson freed up by relocating the passenger loading zone and bike path can be repurposed as permitted parallel or diagonal parking for CCE staff, in order to reclaim any spaces lost in the existing parking space. There is also under utilized city property further south on Anderson which could potentially accommodate additional parking for CCE and Redwood Park.

Nearly every community member benefits under this design concept. The largest beneficiaries are the southbound cycle traffic. With a modest diversion, they now circumvent the CCE drop-off chaos. Northbound through-traffic on Anderson, both motor vehicles and cycles, and including right turns from Rutgers, are not significantly impacted. Southbound through traffic now enjoys a dedicated through lane which avoids the chaos during drop-off. The dedicated left-turn lane for Rutgers is lost¹, but this loss can be mitigated by prohibiting left turns onto Rutgers during peak hours. The neighborhood should benefit from calmer, less chaotic drop-offs. Pedestrians are largely unaffected, as they are already well protected from motor vehicle traffic by signaling and a crossing guard. The sidewalks on both sides of Anderson are not being compromised. However, they stand to

¹In fact, the dedicated left turn lane could be maintained at the expense of some curbside parking spaces.

benefit from better signaling and an improved landing on the side opposite Rutgers. In particular, the dedicated bike lane should eliminate the present conflict between pedestrians crossing Anderson and cyclists heading south or entering CCE campus. The design allows the north end of the CCE parking lot to be reclaimed as a gathering space for humans, and should be improved to include vegetation and shade, while preserving emergency access.

Most of the risk in this design stems from potential misbehavior by drivers. Attempts to access the drop-off from Rutgers or by a left turn from northbound traffic on Anderson can be avoided by adding physical barriers between the drop-off lane and the through lane all the way through the intersection. The on-site drop-off will inevitably be slower than the current system, and this may lead more drivers to use bike lanes, driveways, and bus stops as ad-hoc drop-off locations. This can be discouraged by moving bike lanes closer to the curbs, behind parked cars, and by bumping out bus stops. Some drivers may attempt to use free spots amongst the new parking on Anderson for drop off. This can be discouraged by making sure these spots are designated and enforced as permit only and no stopping. The constriction of through traffic at CCE should naturally slow traffic, but additional traffic calming measures could be added for this highly congested area.

Given the space limitations, on-site passenger loading at CCE will be of limited capacity, and a queue will inevitably spill out into the neighborhood. Quantitative estimates for any design, a plan for accommodating the queue, and managing neighborhood expectations regarding the queue will be essential. It is entirely possible that removing the existing chaotic (and yet effective) curbside parking will make conditions dramatically worse in the neighborhood, and so a pilot study is absolutely essential.

7 Conclusion

This proposal is obviously no replacement for the work of professional civil and traffic engineers. Instead, it is aimed at refocussing those efforts in directions that are more responsive to our community's needs. The presented design concepts illustrate that it should be possible to address the communities priorities while remaining within the community-preserving design constraints. We don't want to tear down any of our few remaining shade trees. We don't want our drop-off traffic queue to spread frustration and chaos into our neighborhood. And we do not need too. We can have safe streets, calmer drop-offs, shady trees, and appealing public spaces. In fact, we insist on it!